The Long-Term Care Funding Checklist

What to write down, look up and ask about while Dad is managing on his own.

Dad is managing on his own and nobody is paying for care. You've started to wonder how the family would pay if that changed, and you know only pieces: a pension, some savings, a policy or two, the house. Check what you've done. Anything unchecked is something to get to when it suits you and Dad, not a verdict about him or about what he has.

Write down

- [ ] Dad's income, source by source: Social Security, any pension, any veterans benefit, and interest or dividends from his accounts. [1]
- [ ] His savings, investments and property, by name. Names are enough to start; you don't need balances.
- [ ] His retirement resources: each retirement account and pension, and the company behind it.
- [ ] If Dad is married, what his spouse relies on now: the home, the monthly income, the household bills.
- [ ] Today's date at the top of the page, and beside each blank, who in the family could fill it in.

Look up

- [ ] Any long-term care insurance policy: the company, roughly when it began, and where the paperwork is. Questions about what it covers go to the policy itself or to the company. [2]
- [ ] Life insurance policies and annuities: what each one is, the company, and when anyone last read it.
- [ ] His health coverage, from the cards and plan papers he has now.
- [ ] Whether Dad served in the military, and any veterans or other benefits he receives or has ever asked about.

Ask about

- [ ] What the different kinds of care could cost where Dad lives, and how long his resources might last. Write these down as questions for a professional. They aren't sums to work out at the kitchen table.
- [ ] Which of Dad's assets may be treated differently for Medicaid purposes. That is a question for your Medicaid planner.
- [ ] What each policy would do if Dad ever needed care. Ask the company that issued it or a licensed insurance professional.
- [ ] The things you've heard, such as that everything has to be spent first, or that money can simply be given away. Write each one as a question, and ask a professional about the possible consequences before any gift or transfer.
- [ ] Which changes in health, finances, marital status or care needs would be a reason to look at this page again.

What this checklist doesn't do

It helps you write down, look up and ask. It doesn't say what a checked or unchecked box means, what care would cost, how long Dad's resources would last, or how Medicaid would treat anything he owns. Rules vary by state and change, so those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional. Nothing here is legal, financial, tax or insurance advice.

Ready for the next step?

You know what to write down, what to look up and what to ask about, category by category. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for care.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The kinds of income in the item marked 1 follow the list on LongTermCare.gov's Medicaid eligibility page. The item marked 2 follows Medicare.gov's suggestion to check a long-term care policy or call the insurance company. The rest come from the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own working list for this step.

1. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Medicaid Eligibility
2. Medicare.gov (Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services), How can I pay for nursing home care?